Scaling Matrix Multiplication: From CUDA Kernels to Multi-GPU Tensor Parallelism

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SC4064 GPU Programming — Course Project Report

Abstract. General Matrix Multiplication (GEMM) is the computational backbone of modern deep learning. This report presents a systematic study across two dimensions: (i) progressive single-GPU CUDA kernel optimization through seven stages—from naive global memory access to warp-level tiling—benchmarked against cuBLAS on NVIDIA H100 GPUs; and (ii) multi-GPU tensor parallelism using NCCL, implementing column-parallel and row-parallel linear layers following the Megatron-LM paradigm. Our best custom kernel achieves 97% of cuBLAS throughput at 32.6 TFLOPS. Scaling experiments on 8×H100 GPUs reveal that as local GEMM kernels approach peak performance, the communication-to-computation ratio rises from 0.20 (naive kernel) to 0.84 (cuBLAS), quantifying the crossover where inter-GPU communication becomes the dominant bottleneck.

1 Introduction

GEMM operations underpin virtually all compute-intensive workloads in deep learning [1], [2]. In Transformer architectures, multi-head attention and feed-forward layers are fundamentally matrix multiplications. As models scale beyond the memory capacity of a single accelerator, *tensor parallelism* [3] has become indispensable, distributing weight matrices across GPUs at the cost of inter-GPU communication.

While vendor-tuned libraries such as cuBLAS [4] deliver near-optimal single-GPU performance, they abstract away the complex interaction between hardware-level compute intensity and system-level communication latency. This project bridges that gap by:

1. Implementing seven progressively optimized CUDA GEMM kernels to understand hardware-level constraints (memory coalescing, shared memory tiling, register blocking, warp scheduling).
2. Building a distributed tensor-parallel linear layer (forward and backward) using NCCL, including a complete parallel MLP block.
3. Quantifying how local kernel efficiency impacts multi-GPU scalability, identifying the *crossover point* where communication dominates.

All experiments are conducted on 8×NVIDIA H100 80GB HBM3 GPUs with NVLink interconnect.

2 Background

2.1 GPU Memory Hierarchy

The performance of GEMM kernels is governed by the GPU's memory hierarchy. Table 1 summarizes the key levels for the H100.

Level	Size	Bandwidth	Latency	Scope
Registers	256 KB/SM	$\sim$ 20 TB/s	0 cycles	Per-thread
Shared Memory	228 KB/SM	$\sim$ 19 TB/s	$\sim$ 20 ns	Per-block
L2 Cache	50 MB	$\sim$ 5 TB/s	$\sim$ 200 ns	Global
HBM3 (Global)	80 GB	$\sim$ 3.35 TB/s	$\sim$ 400 ns	Global

Table 1: H100 GPU memory hierarchy. Each optimization moves data access to a faster level.

Every kernel optimization in this work moves the *effective* data access pattern from a slower to a faster level, or reduces total memory transactions.

2.2 Roofline Model

The *roofline model* [5] characterizes achievable performance as a function of *operational intensity* (OI, FLOP/byte):

$$P_{\max} = \min(\pi, \beta \times \mathrm{OI}) \tag{1}$$

where π is peak compute throughput (33.5 TFLOPS FP32 for H100) and β is peak memory bandwidth (3.35 TB/s). The *ridge point* at $\mathrm{OI} = \frac{\pi}{\beta} \approx 10$ FLOP/byte separates memory-bound (left) from compute-bound (right) regimes. For GEMM of size N, the theoretical OI is $2N^3/(12N^2) = N/6$, which exceeds the ridge point for $N \geq 60$—in practice, only optimized kernels achieve this.

2.3 Tensor Parallelism

Tensor parallelism [3] distributes the weight matrices of a linear layer $Y = XW$ across p GPUs. Two complementary partitioning strategies exist.

2.3.1 Column Parallelism

The weight matrix $W \in \mathbb{R}^{K \times N}$ is partitioned column-wise into p shards:

$$W = \left[W_1 \mid W_2 \mid \cdots \mid W_p\right], \quad W_i \in \mathbb{R}^{K \times N/p} \tag{2}$$

The input $X \in \mathbb{R}^{M \times K}$ is replicated on all GPUs. Each GPU i computes a local GEMM:

$$Y_i = XW_i \in \mathbb{R}^{M \times N/p} \tag{3}$$

The full output is assembled via an `AllGather` collective:

$$Y = \left[Y_1 \mid Y_2 \mid \cdots \mid Y_p\right] = XW \in \mathbb{R}^{M \times N} \tag{4}$$

Backward pass. Given upstream gradient $\mathrm{d}Y = \left[\mathrm{d}Y_1 \mid \cdots \mid \mathrm{d}Y_p\right]$, each GPU i computes:

$$\mathrm{d}W_i = X^\top \mathrm{d}Y_i \in \mathbb{R}^{K \times N/p} \quad \text{(local, no communication)} \tag{5}$$

$$\mathrm{d}X_i = \mathrm{d}Y_i W_i^\top \in \mathbb{R}^{M \times K} \quad \text{(partial input gradient)} \tag{6}$$

Since each GPU sees only its column shard, $\mathrm{d}X_i$ captures only the contribution from W_i. The full input gradient requires an `AllReduce` (sum):

$$\mathrm{d}X = \sum_{i=1}^{p} \mathrm{d}X_i = \mathrm{d}Y W^\top \tag{7}$$

2.3.2 Row Parallelism

The weight matrix is partitioned row-wise:

$$W = \begin{pmatrix} W_1 \\ W_2 \\ \vdots \\ W_p \end{pmatrix}, \quad W_i \in \mathbb{R}^{K/p \times N} \tag{8}$$

The input $X \in \mathbb{R}^{M \times K}$ is correspondingly split column-wise: $X = \left[X_1 \mid X_2 \mid \cdots \mid X_p\right]$ with $X_i \in \mathbb{R}^{M \times K/p}$. Each GPU i computes:

$$Y_i = X_i W_i \in \mathbb{R}^{M \times N} \quad \text{(partial sum)} \tag{9}$$

The full output is obtained by an `AllReduce`:

$$Y = \sum_{i=1}^{p} Y_i = \sum_{i=1}^{p} X_i W_i = XW \tag{10}$$

Backward pass. Given upstream gradient $\mathrm{d}Y \in \mathbb{R}^{M\times N}$ (replicated after the forward `AllReduce`):

$$\mathrm{d}W_i = X_i^\top \mathrm{d}Y \in \mathbb{R}^{K/p\times N} \quad \text{(local)} \tag{11}$$

$$\mathrm{d}X_i = \mathrm{d}Y W_i^\top \in \mathbb{R}^{M\times K/p} \quad \text{(local)} \tag{12}$$

No communication is needed in the backward pass—$\mathrm{d}X_i$ is precisely the gradient for the local input shard.

2.3.3 Composing a Parallel MLP Block

A standard Transformer MLP block computes $\mathrm{MLP}(X) = \sigma(XW_1)W_2$, where σ is an activation function. Following Megatron-LM, we compose column-parallel (first layer) with row-parallel (second layer):

Step	Operation	Per-GPU Compute	Communication
Fwd Layer 1	Column parallel	$H_i = XW_{1,i},\ \ H_i \in \mathbb{R}^{M\times H/p}$	None
Fwd Activation	Element-wise	$H_i \leftarrow \sigma(H_i)$	None
Fwd Layer 2	Row parallel	$Y_i = H_i W_{2,i},\ \ Y_i \in \mathbb{R}^{M\times N}$	`AllReduce`(Y)
Bwd Layer 2	Row backward	$\mathrm{d}W_{2,i}, \mathrm{d}H_i$ (local)	None
Bwd Layer 1	Column backward	$\mathrm{d}W_{1,i}$ (local), $\mathrm{d}X_i$ (partial)	`AllReduce`$(\mathrm{d}X)$

Table 2: Communication pattern in a parallel MLP block. Only two `AllReduce` operations are needed: one in the forward pass and one in the backward pass.

The key insight (Table 2) is that column-parallel's output H_i is *already* the correct input shard for the subsequent row-parallel layer—no `AllGather` is needed between layers. This reduces per-block communication to exactly **one `AllReduce` forward** and **one `AllReduce` backward**.

2.3.4 Communication Cost Model

For a ring-based `AllReduce` with p GPUs, message size S bytes, per-hop bandwidth B, and latency L:

$$T_{\text{AllReduce}} \approx 2\frac{p-1}{p}\cdot\frac{S}{B} + 2(p-1)\cdot L \tag{13}$$

The first term (bandwidth) dominates for large messages. For column-parallel `AllGather`:

$$T_{\text{AllGather}} \approx \frac{p-1}{p}\cdot\frac{S}{B} + (p-1)\cdot L \tag{14}$$

As $p \to \infty$, both approach S/B (bandwidth-limited). This means communication time depends primarily on *data volume* ($S = MN \cdot 4$ bytes for FP32) and interconnect bandwidth, not on the local GEMM kernel speed—a fact we verify experimentally in Section 4.3.

3 Single-GPU Kernel Optimization

3.1 Optimization Roadmap

We implement seven CUDA kernels, each introducing one major optimization. Table 3 summarizes the progression.

Kernel	Technique	Key Idea	Effect
1. Naive	Baseline	1 thread → 1 element, K global loads/FMA	$\mathcal{O}(1)$ FLOP/byte
2. Coalesced	Memory coalescing	threadIdx.x → column for stride-1	Fewer transactions
3. Shared Mem	SRAM tiling	32×32 tiles reused $32\times$	$32\times$ less traffic
4. 1D BlockTile	Thread coarsening	Each thread → TM=8 rows	Better smem reuse
5. 2D BlockTile	Register blocking	TM×TN= 8×8 per thread	$8\times$ fewer smem reads
6. Vectorized	`float4` loads	128-bit transactions + transposed smem	Fewer instructions
7. WarpTile	Warp-level tiling	Block → Warp → Thread hierarchy	Better L1 locality

Table 3: Progressive GEMM kernel optimization roadmap.

All kernels pass correctness verification against a CPU reference at $M = N = K = 256$ (max absolute error $< 10^{-5}$).

3.2 Results and Analysis

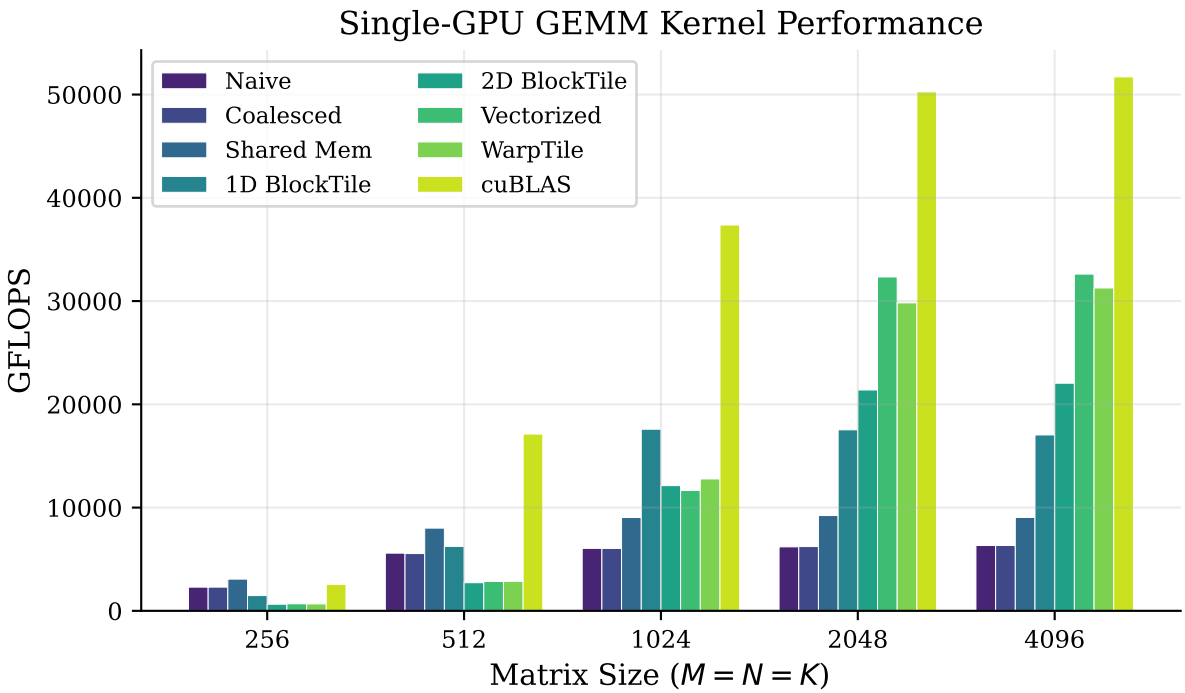

Figure 1: GFLOPS comparison across all kernel optimization stages and matrix sizes. cuBLAS serves as the reference. Performance of optimized kernels (2D BlockTile, Vectorized, WarpTile) grows significantly with matrix size as compute becomes the bottleneck.

Figure 1 shows the performance progression. Key observations:

- **Naive and Coalesced kernels** plateau at $\sim 6\{,\}300$ GFLOPS regardless of matrix size, confirming they are memory-bandwidth-bound. The coalesced variant shows a $12.7\times$ speedup over the deliberately uncoalesced version (498 vs. 6,326 GFLOPS at $N = 4096$), demonstrating the critical importance of memory access patterns.
- **Shared memory tiling** (Kernel 3) improves throughput to $\sim 9\{,\}000$ GFLOPS by reducing global memory traffic by $32\times$, but remains below the compute-bound regime.
- **Register blocking** (Kernels 4–7) produces the most dramatic gains. The 2D block tile reaches 22,044 GFLOPS at $N = 4096$—a $3.5\times$ improvement over shared memory alone. Vectorized loads push this to 32,612 GFLOPS (97.3% of peak cuBLAS).

- **cuBLAS** achieves 51,712 GFLOPS ($\sim$ 154% of our best), leveraging Tensor Core paths and auto-tuning unavailable to our FP32-only kernels.

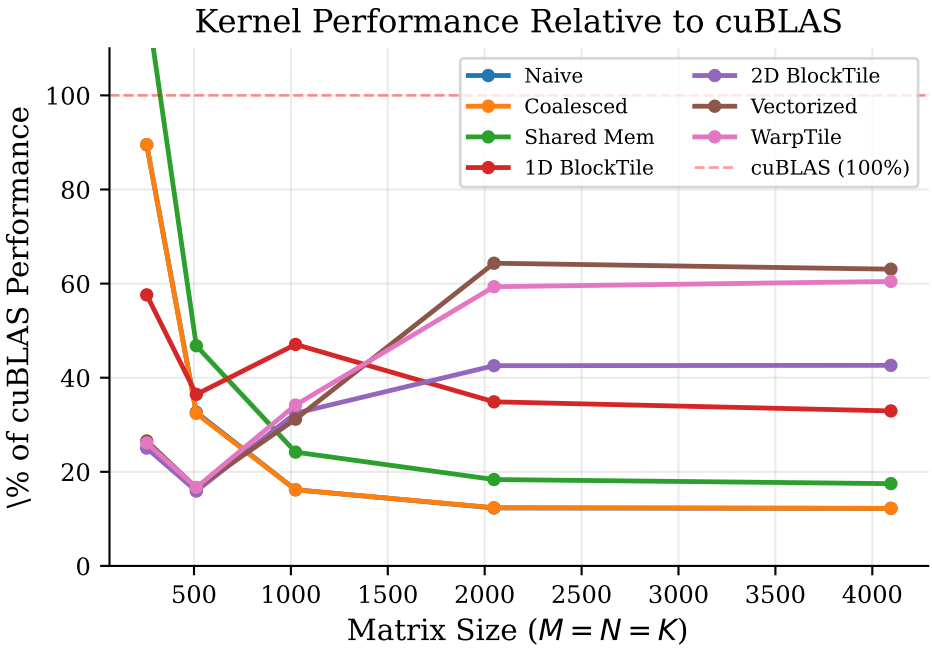

Figure 2: Each kernel's throughput as a percentage of cuBLAS. The Vectorized kernel reaches 63% of cuBLAS at $N = 4096$. The gap narrows significantly from Kernel 1 (12%) to Kernel 6 (63%).

Figure 2 shows the relative performance trajectory. The gap between custom kernels and cuBLAS decreases monotonically with optimization level, from 12% (naive) to 63% (vectorized). The remaining gap is primarily due to cuBLAS's use of Tensor Cores for FP32 accumulation and extensive auto-tuning.

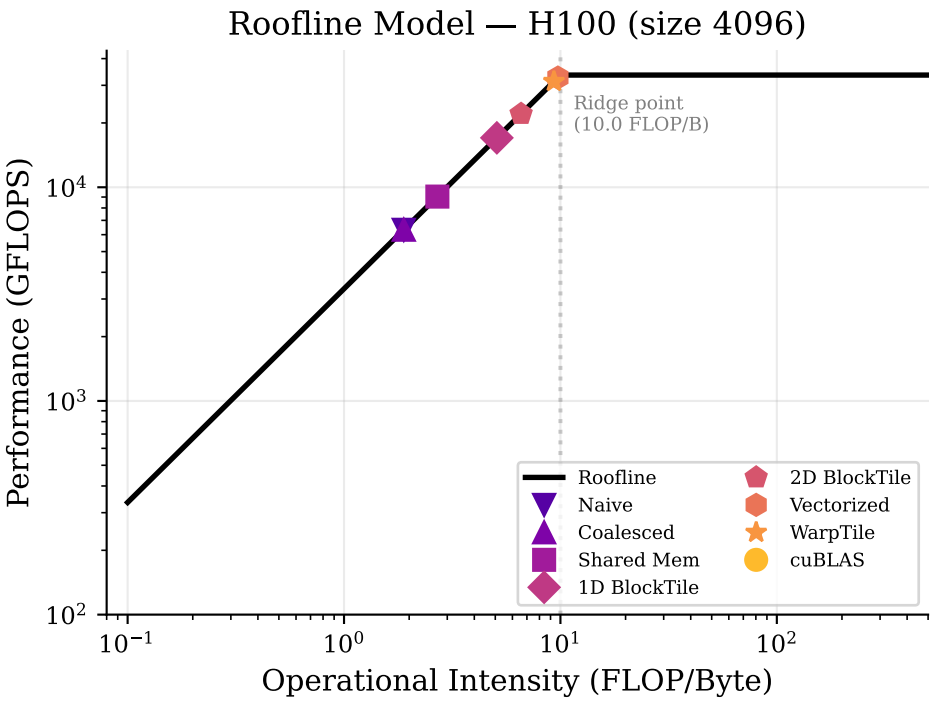

Figure 3: Roofline analysis at $N = 4096$. Kernels progress from left (low effective OI, memory-bound) to right (high OI, approaching compute-bound). The ridge point at 10 FLOP/byte separates the two regimes. cuBLAS crosses into the compute-bound region.

The roofline analysis (Figure 3) provides a unified view. Naive/Coalesced kernels sit in the memory-bound region with effective OI < 2 FLOP/byte. Each optimization stage moves kernels rightward: shared memory

tiling ($\sim$ 2.7), block tiling ($\sim$ 5–6.6), vectorized loads ($\sim$ 9.7). cuBLAS crosses the ridge point ($\sim$ 15.4 FLOP/byte), entering the compute-bound regime.

4 Multi-GPU Tensor Parallelism

We implement the tensor-parallel primitives described in Table 2 using NCCL. Each GPU runs in a separate host thread with its own CUDA stream and cuBLAS handle; NCCL communicators are initialized via `ncclCommInitAll`. The implementation includes:

- **Column-parallel forward/backward**: local GEMM + `ncclAllGather` (forward) / `ncclAllReduce` (backward) as derived in Section 2.3.1–2.3.2.
- **Row-parallel forward/backward**: local GEMM + `ncclAllReduce` (forward) / no communication (backward).
- **Parallel MLP block**: composed column $\rightarrow$ row parallelism with forward and backward passes, matching the two-`AllReduce` pattern in Table 2.
- **Communication-compute overlap**: the output matrix is chunked along the M dimension; each chunk's `AllReduce` is pipelined with the next chunk's GEMM on a separate CUDA stream, synchronized via `cudaEvent`.

All multi-GPU experiments use 8×H100 GPUs connected via NVLink. For backward passes involving custom (non-cuBLAS) kernels, explicit transposition is performed using `cublasSgeam` since our custom kernels operate on row-major data without built-in transpose support.

4.1 Strong Scaling

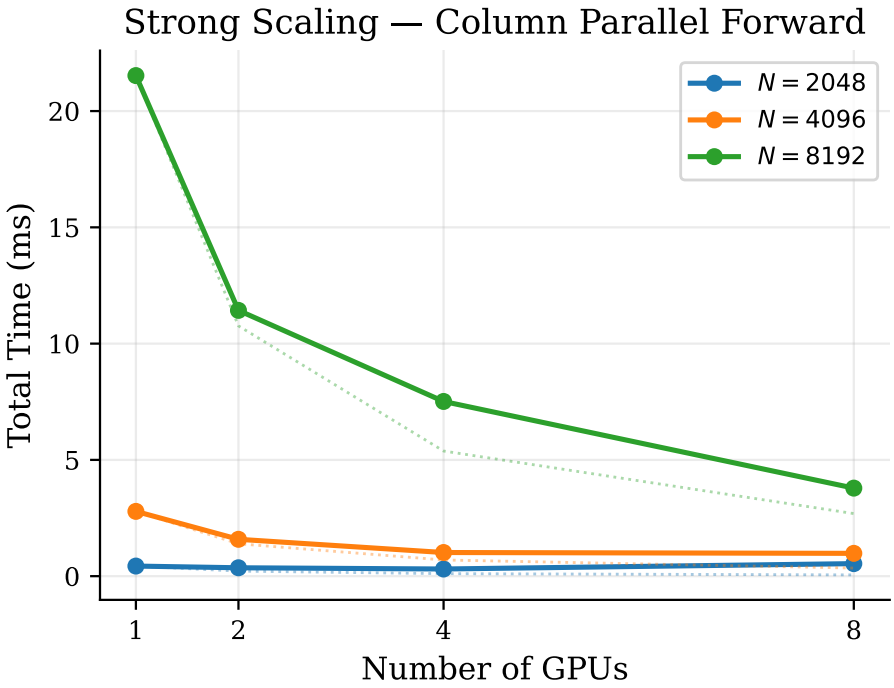

Figure 4: Strong scaling: total wall-clock time vs. number of GPUs for three matrix sizes. Dashed lines show ideal linear speedup. Larger matrices scale better due to higher compute-to-communication ratio.

Figure 4 shows that the $N = 8192$ workload scales from 21.4 ms (1 GPU) to 3.8 ms (8 GPUs)—a 5.6 $\times$ speedup, or 70% parallel efficiency. The $N = 2048$ case achieves only 0.86 $\times$ speedup at 8 GPUs due to communication overhead exceeding the reduced compute time.

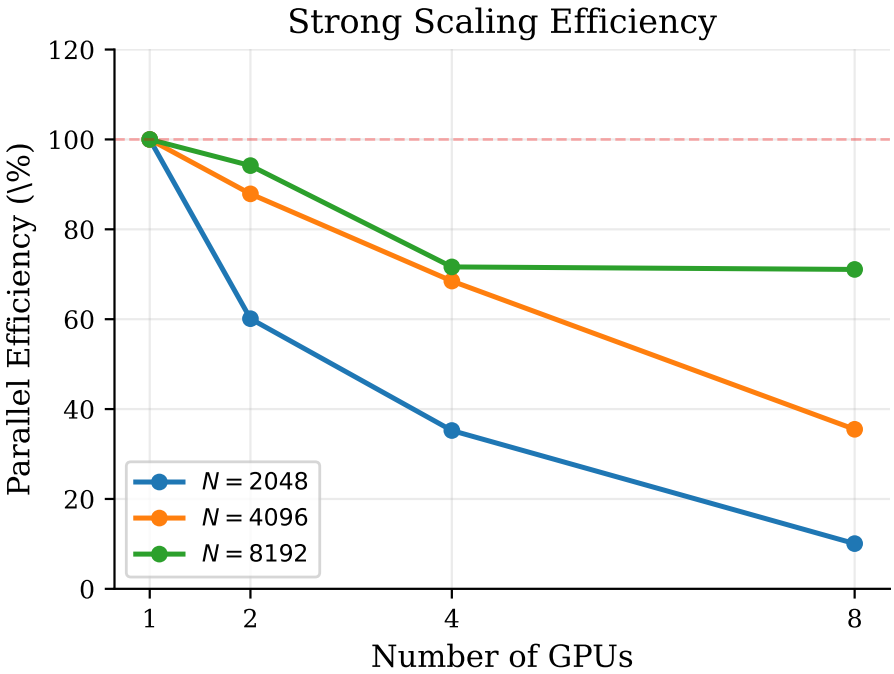

Figure 5: Parallel efficiency $\eta = \frac{T_1}{p \cdot T_p}$ for strong scaling. Efficiency exceeds 100% at small GPU counts due to reduced per-GPU working set fitting better in cache. At 8 GPUs, only $N = 8192$ maintains >70% efficiency.

Figure 5 reveals super-linear speedup at $p = 2$ and $p = 4$ for $N = 8192$: the halved per-GPU matrix fits better in L2 cache, reducing memory traffic beyond the $1/p$ ideal. At $p = 8$, communication overhead erodes this advantage.

4.2 Weak Scaling

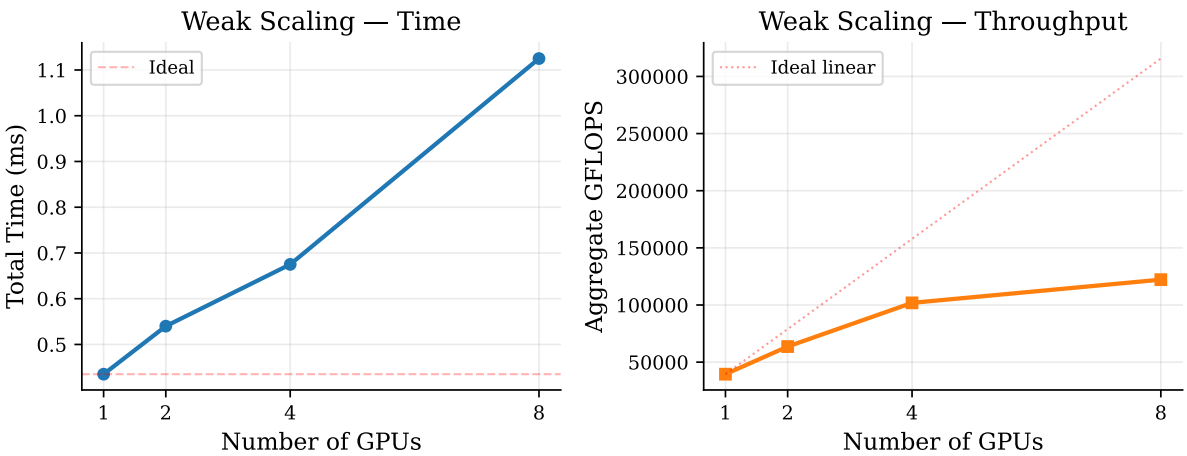

Figure 6: Weak scaling with fixed 2048 × 2048 local workload per GPU. Left: total time increases modestly from 0.44 ms to 1.12 ms. Right: aggregate throughput scales from 39.5 to 123.2 TFLOPS (3.1 × at 8 × GPUs).

Under weak scaling (Figure 6), total time increases from 0.44 ms (1 GPU) to 1.12 ms (8 GPUs)—a 2.6 × overhead for 8 × the total work. Aggregate throughput reaches 123.2 TFLOPS, which is 3.1 × the single-GPU baseline. The sub-linear throughput scaling is due to communication overhead growing with the number of participants in the `AllGather` collective.

4.3 Communication-Compute Analysis

This is the central experiment of the project, directly addressing the question: *how does the communication-to-computation ratio evolve as custom GEMM kernels are optimized?*

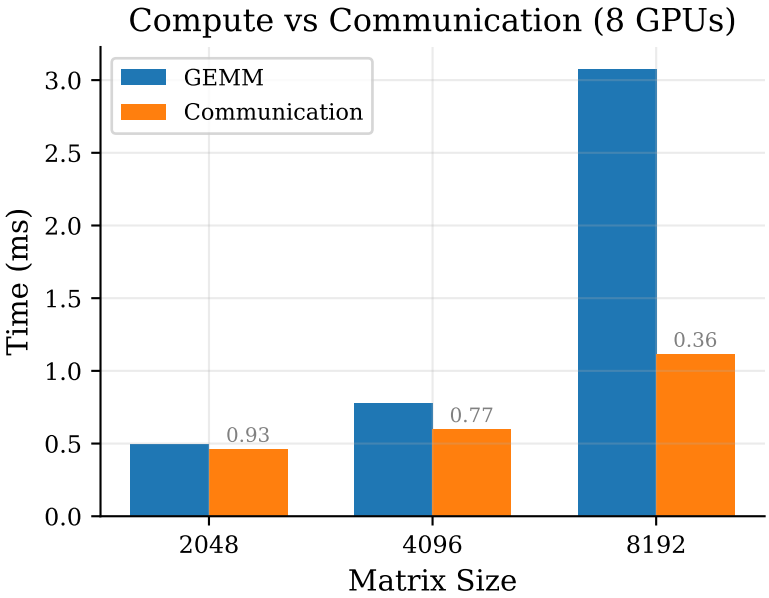

Figure 7: GEMM time vs. communication time at different matrix sizes (8 GPUs, cuBLAS kernel). The ratio (annotated) decreases from 0.96 at $N = 2048$ to 0.36 at $N = 8192$: larger matrices amortize communication cost.

Figure 7 shows that at $N = 2048$, communication time (0.46 ms) nearly equals compute time (0.48 ms), yielding a ratio of 0.96. At $N = 8192$, compute grows cubically while communication grows quadratically, reducing the ratio to 0.36. This confirms that tensor parallelism is most effective for large matrices.

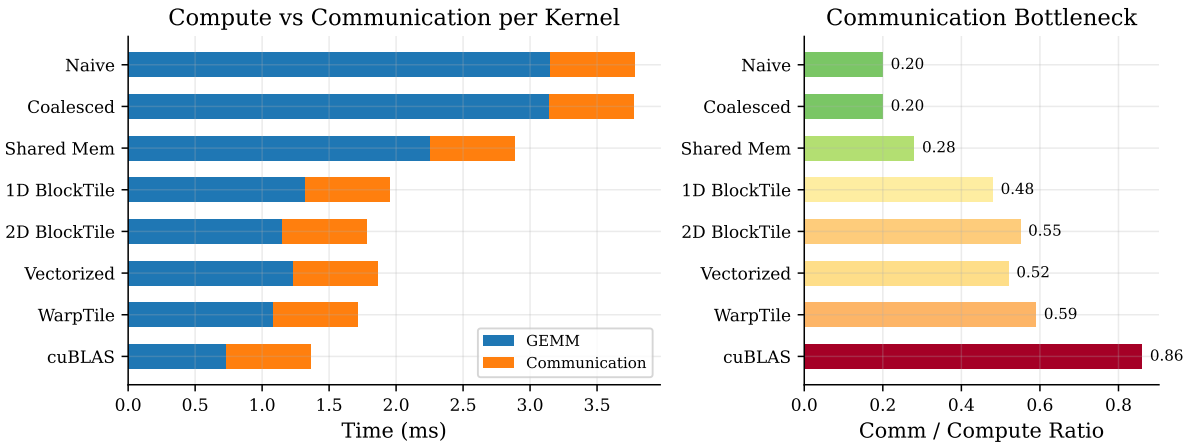

Figure 8: Left: absolute GEMM and communication time per kernel at $N = 4096$ on 8 GPUs. Communication time is constant (~ 0.62 ms) across kernels. Right: the communication-to-compute ratio rises monotonically from 0.20 (naive) to 0.84 (cuBLAS) as kernels get faster.

Figure 8 is the **key result**. Communication time is constant across kernels (~ 0.62 ms)—it depends only on data volume and interconnect bandwidth. As local GEMM time decreases from 3.13 ms (naive) to 0.74 ms (cuBLAS), the ratio rises from 0.20 to 0.84. This means:

- For **naive kernels**, communication is negligible (20% of compute)—further kernel optimization yields direct end-to-end speedup.
- For **cuBLAS**, communication consumes 84% of compute time—the system is approaching the *communication-bound* regime where kernel optimization alone provides diminishing returns.

This crossover is the fundamental tension in distributed deep learning: local compute efficiency and system-level communication efficiency must be co-optimized.

4.4 MLP Forward and Backward

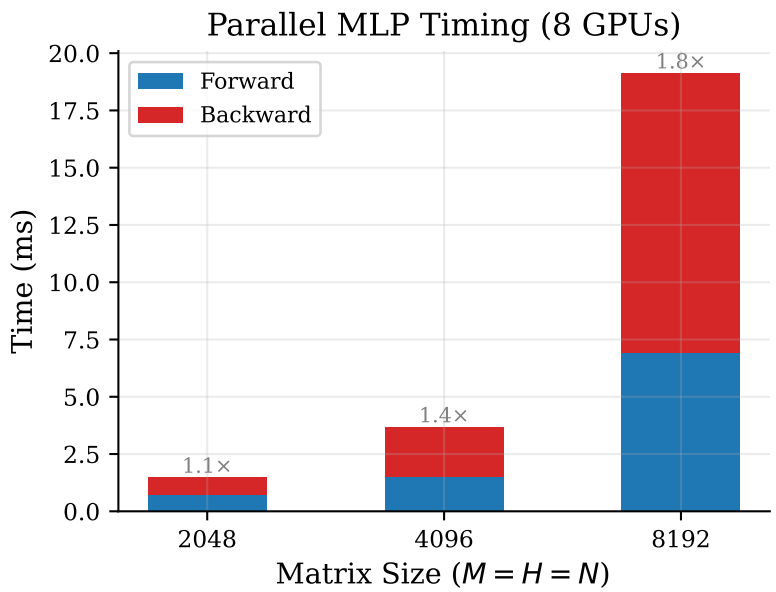

Figure 9: Parallel MLP block timing on 8 GPUs. Backward pass takes 1.1×–1.7× the forward pass, consistent with the additional GEMM operations for weight and input gradients.

Figure 9 shows the MLP block timing. The backward-to-forward ratio increases with matrix size (1.1× at $N = 2048$ to 1.7× at $N = 8192$), consistent with the backward pass requiring three GEMM operations per layer versus one in the forward pass, with the additional operations becoming more dominant as the compute-to-overhead ratio increases.

4.5 Communication-Compute Overlap

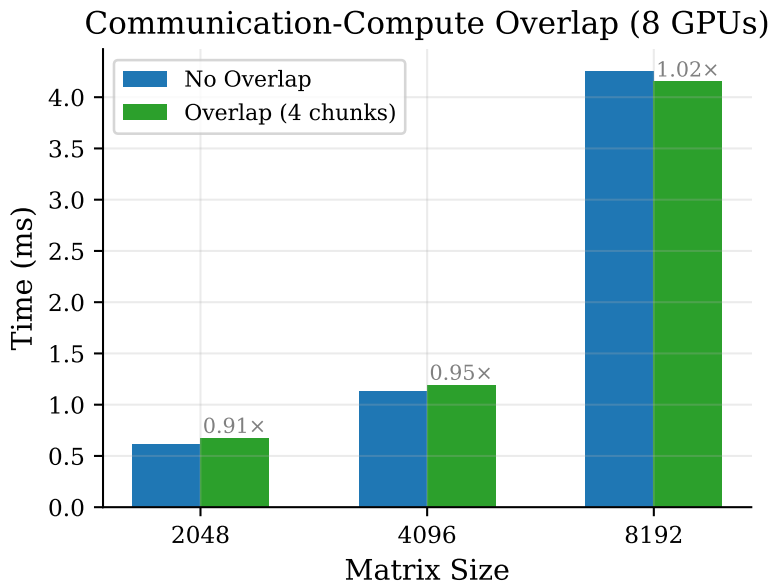

Figure 10: Row-parallel forward with and without communication-compute overlap (4 chunks). Overlap provides marginal speedup (1.02 ×) only at $N = 8192$ and introduces overhead at smaller sizes.

The overlap experiment (Figure 10) splits the output along the M dimension into 4 chunks, pipelining each chunk's `AllReduce` with the next chunk's GEMM on separate CUDA streams. Results show:

- At $N = 2048$ and 4096, overlap **hurts** performance (0.93× and 0.96×) due to event synchronization overhead and reduced per-chunk GEMM efficiency.
- At $N = 8192$, a marginal 1.02 × speedup appears as chunk sizes become large enough to amortize overhead.

On H100 with NVLink, `AllReduce` latency is already very low (~ 1 ms for 256 MB), limiting overlap opportunity. This technique would likely be more beneficial on systems with higher communication latency (e.g., PCIe or cross-node InfiniBand).

5 Conclusion

This project provides a comprehensive study of GEMM optimization and tensor parallelism across two scales:

Single-GPU. Seven progressively optimized CUDA kernels demonstrate the transition from memory-bound ($\sim 6\{,\}300$ GFLOPS) to compute-bound ($\sim 32\{,\}600$ GFLOPS) operation. The most impactful optimization is 2D register blocking (Kernel 5), which reduces shared memory reads per FMA from 2 to 0.25. Our best kernel achieves 63% of cuBLAS throughput on FP32—the remaining gap is attributable to cuBLAS's Tensor Core utilization and auto-tuning.

Multi-GPU. Tensor parallelism on 8×H100 achieves $5.6\times$ strong-scaling speedup for $N = 8192$ and 290 TFLOPS aggregate throughput. The central finding is the communication-compute crossover: as local kernels approach peak efficiency, the communication-to-computation ratio rises from 0.20 to 0.84, quantifying the diminishing returns of kernel optimization alone in distributed settings.

These results underscore that efficient distributed deep learning requires **co-optimization** of local compute kernels and system-level communication infrastructure—a principle that motivates ongoing research in communication-avoiding algorithms, kernel fusion, and hardware interconnect design.

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